By **BHAWANA SOMAAYA**
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With a Twist and a Swirl

A trained dancer herself, the ace chronicler of Bollywood picks her top filmi *naach gaana*



Aplam Chaplam

***Azaad* (1955)**

This was perhaps the first time Hindi film audiences saw a classical style—Bharatanatyam—in its purest form. Even the interlude music is full of *jatis*. Choreographed by Hiralal, it's best known for showcasing two pairs of sisters: Sayee-Subbulakshmi, the dancing duo that ruled the 1950s, were on screen. Usha-Lata, the Mangeshkars, their voices as supple as ballerinas, ventriloquised them backstage. Movement, exuberant and graceful and always incredible, is in perfect sync here with expressions. Sixty-seven years later, you still cannot make up your mind which sister is dancing better. It's a beautiful demonstration of how it is possible to marry a classical dance to a filmi tune. The sheer skills make it a piece still hard to replicate.

Pyaar Kiya Toh Darna Kya

***Mughal-E-Azam* (1960)**

If K. Asif's magnum opus is so universally seen as a classic, a key reason for it is the unforgettable song/dance sequences: they continue to set a benchmark that filmmakers can only try in vain to emulate. *Mohe Panghat Pe*, with its lovely demonstration of *abhinaya*, deserves to be on any best-of list, but Kathak guru Lachchu Maharaj takes it a notch higher here. A visual treat, the song captures all of Mughal palace grandeur—the shot of Anarkali's *chakkar*s reflected in the mirrored ceiling is iconic as love, momentarily, conquers might. Madhubala is radiant as the rebel with a cause, audaciously speaking (and dancing) truth to power.



